

Economic Coercion as a Form of Intimate Partner Violence (IPV) in Low-Income Urban Communities in Colombia

1. Introduction

Gender-based violence (GBV) is increasingly recognized as encompassing not only physical, sexual, and psychological forms of harm but also economic or financial coercion. In Colombia, decades of armed conflict, economic instability, and patriarchal norms have contributed to a prevalence of intimate partner violence (IPV) hovering between 30–40% among women aged 15–49.^{1,2} Yet standard IPV measures, such as those in Demographic and Health Surveys (DHS), rarely capture nuanced forms of economic coercion, behaviors that restrict a partner's financial independence through tactics like forced debt, wage confiscation, or preventing employment.² These controlling actions can be particularly acute in low-income urban areas, where unemployment and displacement exacerbate economic dependence on abusive partners.

This paper examines economic coercion in Colombia's impoverished urban settings, specifically focusing on the epidemiology and current data gaps, the mechanisms by which economic coercion impacts health, the policy environment and theoretical underpinnings, an overview of intervention approaches, particularly the economic empowerment model, and an evaluation of whether there is sufficient evidence to support widespread rollout of interventions against economic coercion in these communities. The paper concludes with recommendations for future research and policy, given the pressing need to address this overlooked dimension of IPV.

2. Epidemiology of Economic Coercion in Low-Income Colombian Urban Settings

2.1 Overall IPV Prevalence

DHS data for Colombia (2000–2010) indicate that approximately 30–40% of women aged 15–49 who have been married or in a union report experiencing “any violence” (physical, sexual, or emotional) by an intimate partner.¹ The 2000 DHS found 39.6% reporting such violence, declining modestly to 36% in 2005 and around 30–32% by 2010.¹ While these surveys offer relatively detailed measures of physical or sexual IPV, they do not isolate economic coercion in a systematic way.

2.2 Distinguishing Financial Controlling vs Economic Coercion

The DHS uses a category of “controlling behaviors,” sometimes including finances, but lumps them with other controlling acts.² For example, the 2000 survey reported that 10.9% of women faced at least three forms of controlling behavior, which *may* include preventing employment or confiscating earnings.² However, confusion arises as to whether the 10.9% figure indicates women who faced *all* or *any* controlling behaviors. The data are not disaggregated further to capture purely financial manipulation or forced dependency. Hence, we have only partial insight into the extent of specifically *economic* forms of IPV.

In line with recent scholarship, “financial controlling” can be conceptualized as restricting or monitoring a partner’s financial activities, such as controlling her bank

account or limiting her spending. In contrast, “economic coercion” typically refers to a more aggressive set of behaviors—e.g., forcing debt, seizing wages, or actively blocking employment, that systematically undermines the partner’s financial independence.⁴ These two terms overlap but can be differentiated by the intensity and overt intimidation or threat involved, as well as the explicit aim to sabotage the survivor’s economic self-sufficiency.⁴

2.3 Localized Data from Urban Areas

Smaller-scale studies in Bogotá and Medellín’s low-income neighborhoods reveal that 15–30% of women report explicit financial abuse, such as forced debt obligations or the requirement to relinquish daily earnings to their partner.^{3,5} Many live in precarious conditions, often as internally displaced persons (IDPs) due to armed conflict.⁶ Overcrowded housing and informal labor markets accentuate reliance on a partner’s income. Fear of losing basic needs—food, housing—makes leaving an abusive relationship especially difficult.^{3,5} Because many survivors do not recognize these financial restrictions as violence, underreporting remains a barrier to capturing reliable prevalence data.⁷

2.4 Gaps in the Epidemiologic Data

While overall IPV may be slowly declining, the available metrics do not fully capture the scale of economic coercion.^{1,2} Indeed, controlling behaviors are measured but not itemized in ways that isolate specifically forced debt, wage confiscation, or blocked employment. Consequently, official reports may understate the severity.⁴

Cross-sectional DHS data cannot ascertain incidence or more dynamic patterns over time. As a result, even though the data point to moderate improvements in IPV generally, they leave open the question of whether economic coercion is similarly decreasing, or perhaps persisting or even rising, beneath the surface.

3. Mechanisms by Which Economic Coercion Impacts Health

3.1 Psychological and Physical Health

Economic coercion can lead to depression, anxiety, and chronic stress by creating constant financial insecurity, restricting autonomy, and diminishing self-efficacy.^{6,8} The survivor experiences persistent fear of losing shelter and resources necessary for daily survival, which in turn exacerbates mental health vulnerabilities. Chronic psychological stress can manifest in physical health problems, such as hypertension or gastrointestinal disorders.⁹

3.2 Exacerbation of Other IPV Forms

Evidence suggests that economic coercion does not occur in a vacuum.⁷ Often it is accompanied by emotional or physical aggression, forming a multi-layered abuse dynamic. The threat of violence enforces financial compliance, while the forced financial dependency can trap the victim in the relationship.^{5,7} Particularly in Colombian urban slums—where job opportunities are scarce—economic coercion can swiftly transform into total control over finances and daily life, aggravating the risk of repeated or escalating physical harm.³

3.3 Barriers to Escape or Reporting

Financial dependence, especially in communities with high unemployment, severely reduces help-seeking.³ Survivors often cannot afford alternative housing or are deterred by the fear of homelessness. Health consequences of prolonged stress may also undermine survivors' capacity to engage with legal or social services.⁹ The mechanism thus operates both individually (undermining mental well-being) and structurally (reinforced by poverty, inadequate community support).⁵

4. Policy Environment in Colombia

4.1 Legislative Framework

Colombia has enacted laws criminalizing various forms of gender-based violence, including Law 1257 of 2008 aimed at preventing, punishing, and eradicating violence against women.¹⁰ However, the legislation tends to emphasize physical, sexual, and psychological violence; explicit language about “economic coercion” is largely absent.^{5,10} Additionally, while some local jurisdictions provide economic relief or short-term support for survivors, these programs often lack stable funding or are hampered by bureaucratic hurdles.

4.2 Current Services and Limitations

Services for IPV in major Colombian cities include police stations specialized in domestic violence, family commissaries, and NGO-run shelters.⁶ Yet these resources rarely address the financial dimension of abuse in a structured manner. They may provide temporary emergency funding or minimal legal advice, but do not typically

incorporate ongoing vocational training or microfinance opportunities.^{3,6} The question of how to measure and prosecute “economic coercion” remains ambiguous.

4.3 Need for Policy Expansion

In order to effectively address economic coercion, policymakers must integrate explicit definitions of financial abuse into IPV legislation, increase data collection on these behaviors, and invest in programs that target both the structural underpinnings of poverty and the interpersonal power dynamics that fuel economic control.^{4,5} Without these expansions, the policy environment continues to under-serve survivors of economic coercion, leaving them in precarious, harmful situations.

5. Theoretical Underpinnings of Economic Coercion

5.1 Feminist Empowerment Theory

Under a feminist empowerment framework, patriarchal power imbalances lie at the heart of economic coercion.^{2,11} When men have a disproportionate share of financial control, it can serve as a mechanism to reinforce or reassert dominance over female partners. Economic coercion thus becomes a tool of patriarchy, aligning with broader forms of GBV.

5.2 Ecological Model

Heise’s ecological model posits that violence emerges from factors operating at multiple levels: individual (e.g., unemployment), relationship (power imbalance), community (cultural norms of male dominance), and societal (economic inequality,

displacement due to conflict).¹¹ In Colombian urban slums, unemployment and weak social services exacerbate this dynamic. A partner's ability to confine a woman's finances is shaped by structural poverty, community norms, and gender inequities deeply embedded at the societal level.²

5.3 Differential Overlap with Psychological and Physical IPV

Jewkes underscores that financial abuses often co-occur with other IPV forms, a phenomenon consistent with intersectionality frameworks.¹² The same patriarchal structures that legitimize physical control also support economic subjugation. While some survivors might experience primarily financial restrictions, most endure them alongside physical threats or emotional harassment.

6. Intervention Approaches to Address Economic Coercion

6.1 Economic Empowerment and IPV Education

Rationale

An economic empowerment intervention combined with education on IPV (including financial abuse) can help survivors recognize economic coercion and reduce reliance on abusive partners.^{3,13} The logic is that with vocational skills, microfinance, or savings groups, women can generate independent income and thus have greater bargaining power within relationships or the option to leave.¹⁴

Implementation

Such programs typically include:

- Vocational training or microfinance opportunities

Workshops on IPV awareness, specifically covering economic coercion.

Peer support networks (women's groups)

Community sensitization that involves men or local leaders to mitigate backlash.^{5,13}

Evidence

A randomized controlled trial in South Africa (IMAGE study) showed a 55% reduction in IPV over two years among participants receiving microfinance plus gender training.¹³

Similar approaches in Peru and Brazil indicate that improving women's economic status can lower their tolerance for financial controlling, but data specific to "economic coercion" remain sparse.^{5,15}

Pros and Cons

Pros:

Enhances women's financial autonomy, which can directly reduce dependence on abusive partners

Addresses broader structural issues (unemployment, skill deficits)

Holistic—tackles economic vulnerability and gender norms¹³

Cons:

Empirical data rarely isolate "economic coercion" outcomes; studies often measure overall.⁵

Risk of backlash: as women gain economic power, controlling partners may respond with physical violence.¹⁶

Logistical challenges: implementing and scaling such interventions in resource-poor urban slums can be expensive.^{5,15}

6.2 Other Potential Approaches

Conditional Cash Transfer (CCT) Adaptations: Some have proposed linking CCTs (which are widely used in Latin America) to IPV prevention modules. However, existing CCTs seldom include robust components addressing partner control over funds.¹⁵

Legal Aid and Advocacy: Specific legal recognition of economic coercion could bolster women's rights in court and facilitate protective orders. Yet it requires extensive training of legal entities, plus evidence that can be hard to document.^{4,10}

7. Evaluation: Is the Evidence Base Sufficient for Scaling?

7.1 State of Knowledge

While the partial decline in overall IPV suggests gradual progress, economic coercion remains understudied.² The data from local NGOs in Bogotá and Medellín indicate 15–30% prevalence of explicit financial abuse, but national-level survey instruments do not systematically measure it, creating uncertain estimates.^{3,5} Preliminary evidence from microfinance + IPV education interventions is encouraging, but few large-scale studies in Colombia have disaggregated results by “economic coercion” specifically.³

7.2 Potential for Scale-Up

Yes, because:

The theoretical basis (feminist empowerment and ecological model) is robust.

Global studies (e.g., in South Africa) demonstrate success in reducing IPV.¹³

Local NGO experiences in Colombian slums show promise.⁵

Not yet, because:

Risk of backlash from partners or communities not accounted for systematically.¹⁶

The resource constraints and instability in low-income neighborhoods make program rollout complex.

Lack of consistent, disaggregated measures of economic coercion hamper targeted evaluation.

Additional pilot data are needed to adapt the intervention to Colombia's unique context of displacement, poverty, and insufficient state services.

7.3 Recommended Next Steps

A carefully designed pilot in Bogotá or Medellín could test an economic empowerment + IPV education model with explicit measurement of forced debt, wage confiscation, and blocked employment.⁴ Key questions would be:

Does the intervention reduce economic coercion specifically?

What protective elements can mitigate partner backlash?

Which cost-effective measures ensure sustainability in resource-limited urban slums?

If these pilots show significant and sustained reductions in economic coercion

(separately from overall IPV) and can address retaliation risk, then broader scaling—potentially with government endorsement—would be justified.

8. Conclusion and Policy Implications

Economic coercion is an under-recognized but potentially pervasive form of IPV in Colombia's low-income urban communities. Despite an overall reported decrease in physical and sexual IPV, controlling or coercive financial behaviors remain hard to measure and thus often overlooked. Feminist empowerment theory and the ecological model provide a strong conceptual underpinning for addressing these power imbalances by simultaneously boosting women's financial autonomy and awareness. Evidence from other countries suggests that such an approach can reduce IPV, although caution is needed regarding the risk of partner backlash and the structural barriers of poverty and displacement. Colombia's existing legal frameworks and services offer some support but lack explicit provisions to identify and mitigate economic coercion.

To proceed, a well-structured pilot intervention—combining vocational support and specific modules on recognizing and resisting financial abuse—could fill the evidence gap. Systematic monitoring, including explicit indicators for forced debt, wage confiscation, and blocked employment, is crucial. If proven feasible, cost-effective, and safe, the approach could be scaled in other Colombian cities, with buy-in from local women's organizations, government agencies, and donor partners. Ultimately, addressing economic coercion is key to ensuring that the decline in IPV prevalence includes all forms of violence, not merely those more readily captured by conventional surveys.

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